If our universe *were* fated to someday suffer a Big Crunch, the first hint would be seen via just such an extrapolation. Before the collapse began, we'd be able to see that the expansion was faster in the past and had been slowing down, in a specific, doom-precipitating kind of way. Over time, with an increasing degree of certainty, we'd get signs of impending collapse many billions of years before it officially started.

But before we get into the data analysis, let's stop to ask what the transition to a contracting universe and eventual apocalypse would look like, once it gets going. That's really what you're here for, after all.

Right now, the more distant an object, the faster it recedes, and therefore the higher its redshift (the Hubble-Lemaître Law). In a collapse-fated universe, this pattern will continue right up until the expansion stops completely—that top-of-the-roller-coaster moment. But since the speed of light prevents us from seeing the entire universe at once, we will still *perceive* distant objects receding long after they start turning around in actuality. Even though in some global sense the most distant objects are barreling toward us more quickly than nearby ones, at first we see the opposite behavior. Every galaxy nearby, out to just beyond our cosmic neighborhood, will appear to slowly come toward us. As with the Andromeda Galaxy, its light will be blueshifted. Just beyond those, there will be a distance at which everything seems to be standing still, while more distant things are redshifted, seeming to recede. Over time, the blueshifted nearby galaxies approach faster and faster, and the standstill radius moves out. Soon, we all stop worrying about what's happening to distant objects as the rush of nearby galaxies into our region of space becomes impossible, or at least highly inadvisable, to ignore.

We might be slightly (if naively) reassured by the fact that we will have had some experience with such things by then: in this scenario, the first signs of collapse come long after our collision with Andromeda. Even with the most pessimistic estimates, any Big Crunch event can only occur many billions of years in the future—our universe has been around for 13.8 billion years and with respect to the possibility of future collapse, it is definitely no more than middle-aged.

As we already discussed, the Andromeda–Milky Way collision is unlikely to affect the Solar System directly. But the onset of universal collapse is another story entirely. At first, it might look fairly similar: galaxies colliding and rearranging, new stars and black holes igniting, some